

Building and Leading Corporate Intelligence Teams

Practitioner Perspective

Introduction

While intelligence has traditionally been the domain of government, corporations are increasingly building in-house intelligence teams to address strategic and operational risk. Functions such as cyber threat intelligence and fraud intelligence remain the most common requirements, but companies are also investing in geopolitical, insider, third party, investigative support, and criminal intelligence teams to meet their intelligence needs. The role of the intelligence team in the corporate setting is to contextualise intelligence against enterprise risk, leveraging a variety of paid and open collection sources to inform analysis and meet these organisational needs.

There are challenges in this emerging field. Sourcing expert staff who can bring an intelligence mindset to a corporate environment remains difficult, and the nature of business means that demonstrating the value of intelligence to leaders is a continuous process. Capabilities need to be shaped to meet resource constraints and requirements of the organisation, with continuous reinvention as priorities shift. Corporations can also be organisationally complex with competing requirements and overlapping areas of responsibility making stakeholder engagement challenging. Nevertheless, there is a growing appetite for intelligence within corporations, for both in-house and externally managed capabilities.

Intelligence in the corporate setting

The term intelligence is included in the titles of a range of corporate functions. Most of these perform business intelligence, where insights into performance across business, staff, or finance are analysed to produce insights for leadership. This important function shares a name with what we'd understand intelligence to be but is ultimately the delivery of metrics to an executive audience. There are also businesses, mostly outside Australia, who maintain competitor intelligence functions to monitor their competition. These operate in a shadier place where collection resources target competitor pricing and technology to drive business decisions. This is closer to what would be considered intelligence in a security context, aligned with economic and technology requirements.

Where there is most significant overlap with traditional government intelligence functions is the threat intelligence capabilities maintained by a growing number of companies across Australia. Within these some of these functions, there is innovative, doctrinally sound

intelligence occurring which intelligence professionals would recognise. These functions are often staffed by professionals from government, military and policing backgrounds, repurposing tradecraft and managerial principles for a corporate context. Unlike other corporate functions with intelligence in their names, threat intelligence functions will have an adversary, including fraudsters, criminals, cyber threat actors, and insider threats. They will often be externally facing, building an understanding of the threat landscape before contextualising it to the organisation they are tasked with protecting.

For simplicity, this paper will focus on threat intelligence functions which service security risk in organisations, as risk is the ultimate driver of the need for corporate threat intelligence functions. Armed with quality strategic and operational intelligence, risk owners can be effectively informed about the threats the organisations are facing. This intelligence is then used, alongside other sources of information, to design controls which eliminate or reduce the risks that the organisation is facing. In this way they operate similarly to familiar intelligence functions in government. Some organisations with regulatory obligations, particularly organisations operating critical infrastructure or other regulated assets, are often required to have intelligence functions, particularly cyber threat intelligence capabilities. Certain information security standards, such as ISO/IEC 27001 and the NIST Cyber Security Framework, also require organisations to ingest threat intelligence to meet the standard. The combination of reducing risk, government compliance, and meeting industry standards all contribute to an increasing appetite for corporations to build intelligence functions.

The question of where intelligence capabilities sit in an organisation has a significant input into the focus of a team. At the domain level, intelligence functions will most often sit alongside the operational elements which are being supported by the intelligence team. Examples include security intelligence analysts being part of corporate investigative functions, cyber threat intelligence teams sitting inside security operations centres, and fraud intelligence teams operating alongside regulatory compliance or operational risk teams. The most common alternative is for intelligence functions to sit within enterprise risk which is suitable where the intelligence required is more strategic or focussed on briefing senior executive audience. Large organisations will often have several thematically-aligned intelligence teams operating in silos with different tooling, skills, expertise, and objectives.

The alternative to intelligence teams aligned to thematic requirements is a converged intelligence team servicing multiple stakeholders. These teams will still generally focus on a single domain such as security but will produce intelligence to meet a range of requirements. They work best as a combination of intelligence generalists and domain

experts, with analysts often responsible for supporting specific reporting lines but able to pivot rapidly between target sets. These teams are often staffed by more experienced analysts, ideally by individuals who have worked across multiple target sets prior to joining corporate intelligence functions. The advantage of a centralised, converged intelligence team is the sharing of analytic expertise and tooling across multiple objectives. A challenge can be prioritising work where there are competing requirements and stakeholders.

The teams also scale differently depending on the resourcing devoted to intelligence. Only the largest corporations in Australia have the resources to maintain intelligence teams, with cyber threat intelligence being the most common type of team found in large organisations. More often large and mid-sized corporations will have, at most, one or two intelligence analysts supporting an operational cyber security capability. Where large security intelligence teams do exist, they are most often 2-7 intelligence analysts led by a manager. Personnel also generally fall into two categories: domain specialists who have skills in technical fields, or intelligence specialists with experience in government or the military. A combination of both types of individuals can address the need for coverage of both a comprehensive understanding of intelligence as a discipline and the requirement that members of small teams need elite target and domain knowledge.

Small intelligence capabilities within corporations can be effective due to the limited remit of intelligence teams and because corporate intelligence capabilities generally do not have to maintain their own collection capabilities. Externally focussed intelligence teams, such as cyber threat intelligence teams, rely heavily on software-as-a-service (SaaS) platforms which collect, process, and alert on information gathered from a range of open and closed online sources. Internally focussed intelligence teams generally rely more on internal telemetry which is collected as part of other functions, such as cyber and data loss prevention events, insider threat alerting, or financial records. In practice, both internal and externally-focussed teams use a combination of both to meet their requirements. Some larger intelligence functions do have their own open-source intelligence capabilities, including dark web monitoring and even threat actor engagement. These capabilities can be problematic, particularly from a legal and reputational perspective, so most organisations do not have an appetite to maintain these specialised skills.

This means that corporate intelligence teams, rather than performing the full set of intelligence cycle capabilities, are primarily analysis and production teams. Where collection management does occur, it's tuning partner SaaS tooling to filter intelligence being delivered to the team. Intelligence functions will generally have very limited insights into the proprietary collection sources used by their SaaS intelligence providers and will

therefore have limited ability to influence collection posture or evaluate collection source effectiveness. The limited remit of all except converged security intelligence teams also simplifies intelligence management by lessening the burden of the requirement gathering, feedback and evaluation parts of the intelligence cycle. Dissemination is predominantly through existing corporate communication channels such as email, chat, or video presentations. This simplifies communicating intelligence to internal stakeholders. The absence of dedicated intelligence dissemination tools does however place restrictions on the collection of performance metrics related to intelligence production.

Building Intelligence Capabilities

Intelligence teams will often emerge from other corporate security functions. Threat intelligence capabilities can begin as a proactive individual using intelligence methods to support an investigative function or as a response analyst ingesting technical threat indicators into detection platforms. This can then build to a full-time employee working as a dedicated intelligence analyst. Finally, a larger team forms with its own remit and management, most often being led by a team lead or manager with 2-7 analysts working to address a risk or support a mission. This organic emergence of an intelligence capability has the advantage of addressing tested requirements within the organisation and its workflows will be aligned to operational functions. The disadvantage is that the processes are not necessarily built to the standards of a government intelligence function, including the team performing activities that would not be considered intelligence outside of a corporate environment.

The second way that intelligence functions can emerge is by a directed action to add an intelligence capability to a security domain. This can be a common response to a request from a regulator, a desire to meet a security standard, or a proactive uplift by security leadership. Where an intelligence function is added to an organisation without any existing intelligence capability the design of the team is critical, ensuring that it is meeting a need and is not producing intelligence for its own sake. A considered assessment of requirements prior to building any intelligence team is necessary, particularly to gauge whether the scale of the capability required matches the resources being made available by the organisation.

Whether formalising an emergent capability or building a new intelligence team from scratch, the intelligence cycle is a useful guide for how to build an intelligence team. Requirements and stakeholder engagement are central, particularly understanding the organisational need and what they consider intelligence to be. In all cases a new intelligence capability will be driven by a key stakeholder, but demonstrating the ability to service a broad range of requirements and teams will strengthen the case for resources.

This is particularly important given that while some security professionals will have a good understanding of intelligence products, they will likely have a limited understanding of intelligence as a process.

The identification of intelligence outputs is the next phase in building an intelligence team. This will be informed by the information requirements of the identified stakeholders, which will then guide the onboarding of intelligence collection sources. The easiest but more expensive option is to onboard intelligence tools which collect, process and alert on information collected from mostly online sources, but sometimes it is appropriate to build collection capabilities in-house. Paid services are almost always a better option for corporations due to the cost and workload of an organisation managing their own collection sources. Concurrent with onboarding collection sources is building the team itself. This is an enormous challenge in the current environment, particularly given the requirement for small teams of intelligence analysts to be staffed by domain specialists with intelligence skills who can perform tasks from strategic reporting through to technical analysis.

The combination of a mission backed by requirements, onboarded collection capabilities, and intelligence analysts to perform the work is a sufficient scaffold to build a basic intelligence team. This will deliver an organisation that can be described as a boutique intelligence capability. These intelligence teams may have standard products or outputs which are regularly produced but will generate most of their intelligence informally and inconsistently using best efforts. While the quality of the intelligence output from these types of capabilities can be excellent, they struggle when scaling their output or providing additional services. The challenge in building intelligence capabilities is therefore as much about hardening them against change, particularly key person risk. Intelligence leaders need to build robust capabilities backed by best-practice intelligence management principles and solid process. Continuous, incremental uplift of immature capabilities needs to focus on regular and structured stakeholder engagement, consistent collection management to ensure only valuable information is reaching analysts, uplifting analyst skill and experience, regularly assessing and introducing new and refined product lines, and, perhaps most challenging, proactively seeking feedback to inform a program of continuous improvement.

Leading Intelligence Capabilities

Large corporations who build intelligence capabilities rarely have security, much less intelligence, as anything other than a critical function to address risk. Instead, these corporations provide financial services, install internet connections, run mines, sell consumer goods, and build infrastructure, as part of a range of other critical elements of

our complex market economy. As such, security is something that is taken care of by individuals who are peripheral to the core business, and implementing security controls is sometimes seen as an impost. Within security functions themselves an intelligence capability can be central to their operating model if a function is intelligence-led. It can however also be an afterthought, an additional small offering because senior executives believe that they need to have an intelligence capability even if they're not entirely sure why.

Across both of these scenarios there can be gaps in understanding of what intelligence is. This most frequently manifests itself when specialists or senior executives claim to have intelligence to share that is instead a rumour which has not been evaluated or subjected to any critical assessment. This misunderstanding fails to consider intelligence as both a process which subjects data and information to analysis as well the output of that process itself. There are often also significant gaps in understanding the level of visibility that intelligence teams have, particularly not appreciating that collection resources are finely tuned and can't easily be re-tasked to threats outside of their specialised function. It is however important to remember that these challenges are not confined to intelligence in a corporate security setting with teams of exceptionally capable individual contributors and leaders each contributing with their own specialised skills and knowledge. As an intelligence leader it is critical to bring other security professionals on a journey to build their understanding of intelligence so that they can more effectively engage intelligence teams and understand its capabilities and limitations.

As a capability, intelligence is generally highly regarded in corporate security teams. The work is seen as valuable and sometimes mysterious, and colleagues are enthusiastic about learning more about intelligence and how it works. This translates into security leaders having faith in intelligence analysts as highly capable problem solvers who they often approach with their hardest issues. The challenge for an intelligence leader is that senior leaders will occasionally ask intelligence teams to perform functions which they are not resourced or sufficiently skilled to perform, such as risk assessments, operational tasks, and assessments of threats outside of their area of expertise. This is particularly challenging when also balancing the enthusiasm of analysts whose disposition is to have a go when faced with a challenge. The intelligence leader needs to understand that their capability is limited, and to be willing to push back when analysts are asked to produce intelligence on topics which they don't have expertise or to perform tasks which should be reallocated to other teams. As a leader it's important reject some requests when it exceeds the capability of the team while understanding the strategic importance of leveraging the team to assist with non-intelligence work where it is appropriate.

The skills expected of an intelligence analyst in the corporate setting are broad to the point of potentially being unreasonable. Intelligence analysts are often expected to monitor feeds for situational awareness, perform post-graduate level research, manage security tickets, produce narrative reporting, analyse of technical data, and brief senior stakeholders on complex threats. The profile of corporate intelligence analysts will be familiar to intelligence professionals: enthusiastic individuals with a broad range of skills who have expertise in a domain of knowledge. While the calibre of general skills and domain expertise is generally excellent, corporate intelligence analysts often don't have experience working in intelligence and certainly do not have the same access to training in intelligence as a discipline as analysts working in government.

This presents challenges to leaders of corporate intelligence teams. Staff are often inexperienced, with analysts often filling senior roles in the first five years of their careers. In the cyber threat intelligence discipline, this is impacted by the newness of the field and the challenges of finding cyber talent in Australia. Given the small size of intelligence teams and broader scale of threat intelligence across the country, corporate intelligence analysts most often haven't been exposed to the range of roles or target exposure that an analyst working in an intelligence agency would as part of, for example, an intelligence graduate program or multiple early career postings. Intelligence training available to corporations is also sparse, varied in quality, and universally expensive, and university courses aren't delivering the types of skills required in corporate intelligence functions. There is no appetite to devote the months of training resources that intelligence agencies or the military spend on developing early career intelligence professionals. It therefore falls to intelligence leaders to use their broader experience to develop intelligence analysts on the job through a combination of formal training and on the job mentoring.

Intelligence functions can also struggle to demonstrate the same value to the business during organisational contraction or restructure. As risk led security functions, there are certain services and controls that corporations must maintain to comply with regulations or standards. Intelligence enhances the effectiveness other security functions rather than controlling risk on its own. It may allow detection and response teams across fraud, cyber security, and physical security to optimise their detection methods through an understanding of threats, but ultimately those functions directly manage a core function while intelligence merely supports them. This means that during periods of organisational contraction intelligence functions may be cut first until the capability is too small to be self-sustaining. Intelligence leaders need to understand the place of intelligence in a corporation whose objective is profit and to periodically reshape intelligence capabilities in line with the scale an organisation is willing to support.

The Future of Corporate Intelligence

Intelligence is unquestionably valuable to security leaders in corporations. Large organisations aspire to be intelligence led in line with best practice, and smaller security teams lament the absence of an intelligence capability when struggling to make strategic and operational decisions. The trend globally is to invest in intelligence capability when building a mature security domain, and at this stage there is ample opportunity to innovate when designing intelligence functions. What has been described above is corporate security intelligence as it is, what follows is an outline of what it could be in years to come.

Intelligence functions operate siloed even within organisations, much less between companies, with the primary axis of structure being along functional lines. For example, cyber threat intelligence teams sit alongside cyber security operations teams, security intelligence analysts are embedded in investigative functions, and fraud intelligence teams sit alongside their colleagues managing regulatory compliance and risk. Fundamentally however, these teams are all producing intelligence despite their different domain expertise. The separation of these teams exposes a weakness of scale: corporate security teams will never be large enough to possess the full cycle of intelligence capabilities available to government agencies and forces. They can produce excellent analysis but struggle with requirement setting, collection management, dissemination, quality control of end products, and robust processes for sharing intelligence. At a small scale, converged security intelligence teams can address some of these issues. However, these teams rarely have the size required for full-cycle intelligence management and simply stretch themselves over a wider target set. The challenge then is to maintain the advantage of intelligence capabilities sitting alongside the operational and strategic capabilities they support while being able to draw on shared resources to manage the intelligence capability.

The model which supports these twin objectives is for a centralised security function leading outposted intelligence analysts and teams which service other parts of the business. A centralised function which handles analyst training, initial stakeholder engagement, requirement setting, feedback and evaluation, collection management, intelligence partner relationships, and reporting standards, would bring corporate intelligence capabilities closer to the level available to government. This function would be responsible for the practice of intelligence while the daily operational management of analytic resources would remain with the operational teams. A capability built on this model scales easily, with individual or small teams of analysts able to be deployed throughout an organisation to achieve their mission while being supported by robust

intelligence practice. There is even the opportunity for centralised collection capabilities such as an open-source intelligence team servicing the outposted analysts.

This model has an analogy in military and policing contexts. Police forces post intelligence analysts to district commands and specialist squads, with analysts taking their mission tasking from their units while leveraging the shared intelligence management resources and surge capability of a centralised intelligence function. Military deployments operate in a similar manner with deployed intelligence cells made of analysts from different services, corps, and specialisations, as well as capabilities drawn from intelligence agencies. In both cases there is a chain of command leading to both unit commanders and the centralised intelligence capabilities from which the resource is drawn. This model easily translates to large corporations aiming to service a disparate variety of business units with intelligence.

Strategic leadership of a centralised intelligence requirement would likely come under a Chief Intelligence Officer (CINO). The concept of a CINO has emerged recently with the position operating similarly to a Chief Legal Officer, providing strategic advice to C-Suite executives and board on strategic intelligence matters. A centralised intelligence capability with access to the intelligence output of the entire organisation would be uniquely equipped to provide strategic advice to decision makers. Leadership by a senior executive with insights into the concerns of decision makers is the most effective way to ensure that intelligence teams are aligned to corporate objectives. The CINO position hasn't been implemented by any global companies. It is however a model for how intelligence can shape strategic corporate decision making similarly to the way senior intelligence agency heads influence government policy.